

and being wilfully ignorant of the factors that contributed to your mistakes. Looking at and understanding the factors leading up to any money mistakes that you might have made does not equate to letting yourself off the hook entirely – it is about seeing what went wrong, so that you know what to do differently if that same set of circumstances occurs again. So that you can show yourself some compassion and understanding, in the same way that you would show both of those things to a close friend or family member who had made an error: of judgement or slipped up in some way.

A lot of my spending issues reached a fever pitch while I was on maternity leave with my second son, in 2018. I look at some of the decisions that I made during that time – upping my credit limits, buying expensive, organic babygrows that he grew out of immediately, hiring a cleaner to come every other week even though we were struggling to make ends meet – and they seem ludicrous at first glance. I certainly found them difficult to forgive for quite a while. But when I switch to a broader lens and look at what was going on outside of those individual transactions, it becomes easier to see what was happening, and why. I was very lonely, exhausted and experiencing fairly all-consuming postnatal anxiety. The leap from one child to two was a shock to the system, and I felt as if I was drowning. When I remember how that felt, it's easier to cut myself a little bit of slack, and consider what I might do differently if we ever decide to have another child (unlikely – he's almost three now, and has slept through the night . . .